

Titles and first lines

TITLES

1. Name the thing.

A stranger should guess your subject. *A Continental Invasion*, not *Impending Doom*.

2. Promise a story.

A person, a risk, a verb that hints at trouble. *Tanner's Gamble*. *How One Man Tried to Fix Lake Michigan*.

3. Steal the author's best phrase.

Lake Erie's Kidney. *Angry Enough to Put the Line Back*.

4. A label is not a title.

Chapter 7 Summary is a file name.

FIRST LINES

1. Start with something you can see.

A thing, a place, a date, a number. *In 1968 Lake Michigan shores were covered with rotting alewives*.

2. Small thing, huge effect.

A single specimen small enough to hide in a boat's bilge can cause problems that span an entire continent.

3. Put the reader somewhere.

Have you ever been fishing on the Great Lakes?

4. Set up a turn.

People overreact all the time. ... and, unfortunately, they might be right.

ALWAYS

- **After the hook, get to the point.**

Within two or three sentences, name the book, the chapter, and what it's about.

- **Cut the throat-clearing:**

It is no secret that, Throughout history, Since the dawn of time.

- **Write your first line last.**

The test for both: could it head someone else's paper? Then it isn't yours yet.